

Burners Company

Ok boys, check your kit, check your weapons, it's today. You get a pint and a chaser, no more. Let's go

How a crew is hired, kept, bonded, and **Mustered**. Pay rates live on [[Burners Equipment#Hirelings]]. Heart 1+ unlocks Muster and Company slots in [[Burners Adventure Game]].

Three Roles

Role	What they are	Level	Dangerous places	Morale	XP
Hireling	Day- or week-rate hand for this job	Fixed at hire (usually 1)	No — camp, wall, town only	Checks	No
Retainer	On keep between jobs — not yet bonded	Fixed at hire (usually 1)	Yes	Checks; puts self first	No — but unslotted they dilute the PC pot ½ Boss award when Mustering; unslotted they dilute like a retainer
Henchman	Sworn companion; trust earned in play	Climbs on bonus XP	Yes	None while Boss is active; prioritizes the Boss	

Anyone with coin can hire. Only a **Boss (Heart 1+)** **Musters** — splitting the twelve into physical kit and **Company** seats, and seating today's crew.

XP and Company seats.

- **PCs** always share the party pot.
- A retainer or henchman who **delves without a Company seat** (no Boss, or the Boss did not Muster them) is an **extra share in the divisor** and **earns none** of it — that slice is gone. Bring an unslotted retainer and the PCs take home less. (Hirelings do not delve, so they never dilute.)
- A hand **Mustered into Company seats** is **off the divisor**. No XP suck. Unlike OSE, the seat is the shield.
- Mustered **henchmen** who survived also receive **bonus XP**: half of the Boss's own award, not taken from anyone. Two or more split that half. Retainers still earn none even when slotted.

Company Hands (half power)

Hands are not Burners. They have a **track level** and place Approaches in **Sword or Craft only** — never Sorcerie, never Heart, never Muster. They hold **2 Traits per track level** (half of a Burner's 4). No Signatures until they become a PC.

Everything that scales with level or Approach is halved, round down (see *Manage* for the only round-up):

Piece	Company rule
Traits	2 per track level
HP	Roll 1d6 per track level , then [total / 2] (minimum 1). On level-up: PC-style reroll (keep higher of new total or old+1), then half again.
Fuel level dice / refill	[track level / 2] , minimum 1
Veteran extras	[Sword / 2] extras (Sword 1 → one attack)
Approach rolls	2d6 + [Approach / 2]
Shock and other Approach math	Same half (Shock: 2d6 + [Sword / 2])

Not halved: Handling, wages, shares, Muster seats, role loyalty, kit on their person. Armor still soaks on the way in. Full Wound and Shock rules apply once HP is spent.

A Burner with Approach 0 in Sword (levels elsewhere) still rolls 2d6 for Sword — that is a different sheet. Do not write company half-math on a PC.

Manage (Boss Action)

Default: half, always round **down**.

Managed: The Boss spends **their Action** that round to **manage** one company hand — bark orders, steady them, point the spear. Until the next Roll Initiative, that hand uses **half round up** instead of down for every half-powered number: Approach rolls, Shock, Veteran extras, Fuel level-die counts that land in that window. HP already on the sheet does not rewrite mid-fight.

- One Action → **one** hand for that round.
- Only a hand you are Mustering or leading — not a stranger across the hall.
- You forgo your own attack, cast, or feat. Sword 1 managed → still one attack; Approach 1 managed → 2d6+1.
- Managing again next round costs another Action.

Role rules and fiction do not flip rounding by themselves.

Traits

Job names are Traits, tagged to Sword or Craft. A hand fills their item slots for that work; the Boss outfits upgrades from the purse.

Packbearers carry baggage and keep simple items handy: rope, waterskin, and the like.

Fighting men hold Sword-tagged Traits for preferred arms and kit — spear, arming sword, shield. They wear what the Boss outfits.

Lantern bearers (linkboys, torchbearers) hold *lantern-bearer* or *torchbearer*. Lantern or torches, flint and steel, oil.

Shield bearers hold *shield* / shield-bearer. They can raise a shield; their chief work is resupplying fighters with fresh boards.

Squires keep weapons ready to hand off (*“Squire, my sword!”*). They may help a fighter don armor.

War dogs hold *bite* (and often a thick hide). A dog’s kit is fangs and whatever collar or armor the fiction allows.

Handling and Company Slots

Each hand needs **Handling** of **1 to 4**. That is how many **Company slots** a Boss must commit at Muster for them to do their job well.

- A docile, responsible torchbearer needs **1**.
- A violent or surly sellsword might need **4**.
- If a hand is not properly handled, they will not do the job well and may cause trouble.

The Referee sets Handling the first time the hand meets real pressure. Apply **+1 or +2** if the job is violence or unruliness. Later, when they have settled with the company, the Referee may lower it. Bonded henchmen who have stayed often sit lower than the day they signed on.

Muster (Heart 1+)

Before a job — gathering the crew in town or at the safehouse — or on any **8-hour sleep**, the Boss **Musters**:

1. Declare the **physical** / **Company** split of the twelve.
2. Seat named hands into Company seats. Each person costs **Company slots equal to their Handling (1–4)**.
3. Lock the Muster for the run until the next Muster.

Going alone: Muster **0** Company, all twelve physical. Bonds wait at home.

Company slots hold **people**, not gear. Their kit rides on them; wages, keep, and new gear come from the Boss's purse. On Roll Initiative the Boss adds **one die per Company slot declared** (filled or empty). Those slots never also count as empty-inventory dice. See [[Burners Adventure Game]].

XP perk of the seats: Mustering pulls a hand **off the XP divisor** (no suck) and lets henchmen draw bonus XP (see *Three Roles* and *Henchmen*). A PC who is not a Boss cannot Muster — their delving retainers always dilute.

Non-Bosses may still hire for coin. Without Muster they do not split Company seats and do not gain Company-slot Initiative. Handling trouble is sharper without a Boss's Morale Check.

Hirelings

Find them in the fiction: a tavern notice, a dockside crew, a debt called in. The offer is a Reaction roll (see [[Burners Referee Guide]]); Heart on the roll if you have it. A generous purse eases it; a bad name hardens it.

Track level is fixed when they hire (usually **1** — Sword 1 or Craft 1, 2 Traits, half HP). They do not rise with the Boss.

Pay the weekly rate on [[Burners Equipment#Hirelings]]. **Hirelings will not enter dangerous places** — no barrow, no delve, no burning hall. Camp, wall, town, and the road between are their work. **Food, lodging, and new gear are on you.** No XP.

Retainers

A **retainer** is on **keep** between jobs — standing hand, still coin, not yet bonded. Same half-power sheet; **track level fixed at hire** (usually 1). They will enter dangerous places and fight, but **put themselves first**. They check Morale. Field them at Muster like any other hand.

XP: Retainers earn **no** XP. If they delve **without** a Company seat, they still **count in the XP divisor** (a pure suck for the PCs). A Boss who Musters them into seats stops the suck — they fight under the packing tax instead.

Promote to henchman only when the bond is real (Referee's call): they stayed when it mattered, you kept your word, you pulled them out of the barrow. They keep their current track level and begin earning henchman bonus XP when Mustering.

Henchmen

A **henchman** is a sworn companion: keep, a half-share of treasure, and a bond earned in play — not a Reaction roll on day one. Only a Boss may hold henchmen.

XP. Figure the award for monsters and recovered treasure. Divide it among **every PC** plus **each unslotted** retainer or henchman who delved — those unslotted hands **earn none** of their share (it is gone). Hands in **Company seats** are **not** in the divisor. Then: each Mustering henchman who **survived** splits **half of the Boss's award as bonus XP** — not taken from the Boss or the other PCs. One henchman: 50% of what the Boss gained. Two Mustering survivors: they split that half (25% each). Track their total on a margin line. They buy character levels on the same XP table as Burners (in civilization), place each level in Sword or Craft only, gain 2 Traits, reroll HP then half. Their track level **never exceeds the Boss's**. Retainers earn no XP even when slotted.

On the delve. Muster them into Company seats. While the Boss is **active** (on their feet, leading), henchmen **do not check Morale** and **do not leave**. They **prioritize the Boss** over others — Block for you first, stay on your heel. They want keep *and* at least a half-share.

Replacing a henchman. Death or departure ends the bond. Word of how you treat henchmen travels; abuse it and the next bond is harder to earn.

Starter. A starting Boss begins with one henchman at level 1: Sword 1 or Craft 1, 2 Traits, HP = $1d6 / 2$ (min 1), basic kit, keep and a share of the take.

Morale

When the company faces something that would break ordinary resolve (a fight turning, a horror from the crypt, a comrade cut down, wages long overdue), and a **Boss** leads, the Referee calls a Morale Check for **hirelings and retainers** who are shaken — **not** for henchmen while the Boss is active:

Morale Check: roll **2d6 + your Heart** against the moment's danger. A routine scare is low. A wraith clawing free of its tomb is high.

- **Meet or beat** → **they hold**.
- **Fall short** → **they break** — flee, freeze, drop the torch, or demand to leave. Play it by fiction.

Leading from the front and keeping your word ease the check; treating hands as arrow-fodder hardens it. Without a Boss, the Referee plays nerve by fiction or calls **2d6 vs the danger** with no Heart bonus. If the Boss is down or gone, henchmen check Morale like anyone else.

Mercenaries (garrison)

Soldiers-for-hire for walls, camps, and armies — not barrow companions. Hire by the month; food and basic kit are in the rate; wages double in wartime.

Troop	gp / month	Troop	gp / month
Peasant levy	1	Archer	5
Light footman	2	Light horseman / longbowman	10
Heavy footman	3	Medium horseman / mounted archer	15
Crossbowman	4	Heavy horseman	20

Their Morale is their own score (6 for a peasant levy up to 9 for mounted troops), checked on 2d6. A Boss on the field may steady them as on a delve.

Becoming a Burner

A company hand becomes a full **Burner** only when they become a **PC** — your next character after the Boss dies, or a player takes them over. Until then they stay on the half-power track. Do not promote a seated NPC to full Burner rules.

On that claim: they are a PC **at their current track level** (henchmen often lag the Boss — half XP pace). Rebuild under full PC rules from then on — 4 Traits per level, full HP, full Approach math, Signatures, open Approaches.

Professional Adventurers

The Referee may field a rare **professional adventurer**: an NPC built as a PC, with their own goals. Uncommon — nearly everyone with a real sheet is a player at the table. This is not a company upgrade path.

Example Hands

All examples use half power (round down) unless a Boss **manages** them that round.

Cob — lantern bearer (hireling)

- **Level 1, Craft 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Fuel level die: 1. Rolls: $2d6+0$.
- **Traits (2):** *lantern-bearer*, *quiet* (Craft).
- **Handling:** 1.
- **Kit:** hooded lantern, flask of oil, flint and steel, spare torch.
- Will not enter the barrow. Quiet, eyes on the floor. A pint settles him; a second and he talks about home.

Merrin — packbearer (hireling)

- **Level 1, Craft 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Fuel level die: 1. Rolls: $2d6+0$.

- **Traits (2):** *packbearer, broad-backed* (Craft).
- **Handling:** 1.
- **Kit:** rope, waterskins, spare rations, room on her back for the haul.
- Camp and road only. Will not leave a pack behind.

Joss — fighting man (hireling)

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Fuel level die: 1. One attack. Rolls: $2d6+0$.
- **Traits (2):** *spear, leather* (Sword).
- **Handling:** 3 (+1 for a violent job).
- **Kit:** spear, leather armor (AC 1), short blade.
- Dockside muscle for walls and gates — not the dark below. Fee in hand before the gate.

Bren — shield bearer (retainer)

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Fuel level die: 1. One attack. Rolls: $2d6+0$.
- **Traits (2):** *shield-bearer, steady* (Sword).
- **Handling:** 2.
- **Kit:** two heaters, a spare buckler, leather.
- On keep. Will delve; puts self first; checks Morale. Resupplies the front when boards splinter.

Tam — squire (retainer)

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1). Fuel level die: 1. One attack. Rolls: $2d6+0$.
- **Traits (2):** *squire, arming sword* (Sword).
- **Handling:** 2.
- **Kit:** master's spare blade sheathed, oil, strap kit; helps don mail.
- Young, proud of the Boss's harness. Checks Morale; looks to his own skin when the line bucks.

Rook — war dog (henchman)

- **Level 1 (climbs on bonus XP).** Sword 1; half power. HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1), one attack, $2d6+0$.
- **Traits (2):** *bite, thick hide* (Sword).
- **Handling:** 2 (settled; was 3).
- **Kit:** the dog — collar, scars, a mean bark in the dark.
- Bonded after the fen job. Mustering draws half the Boss's XP without diluting the party. No Morale while the Boss stands; prioritizes the Boss. Sleeps on the Boss's blanket.

Nell — spear (henchman)

- **Level 1 (climbs on bonus XP).** **Sword 1**, HP $\lceil 1d6/2 \rceil$ (min 1), Fuel level die 1, one attack, rolls $2d6+0$.
- **Traits (2):** *spear, steady under fire* (Sword).
- **Handling:** 1 until first pressure (often rises, then settles).
- **Kit:** spear, gambeson (AC 2), kettle helm — Boss may outfit better from the purse.
- Starter bond for a green Boss. Keep, half-share, checks the kit when Muster is called. No Morale while the Boss is active; prioritizes the Boss.

You don't give your strength away. You make others braver than they have any right to be, and lead them somewhere they'll probably regret.